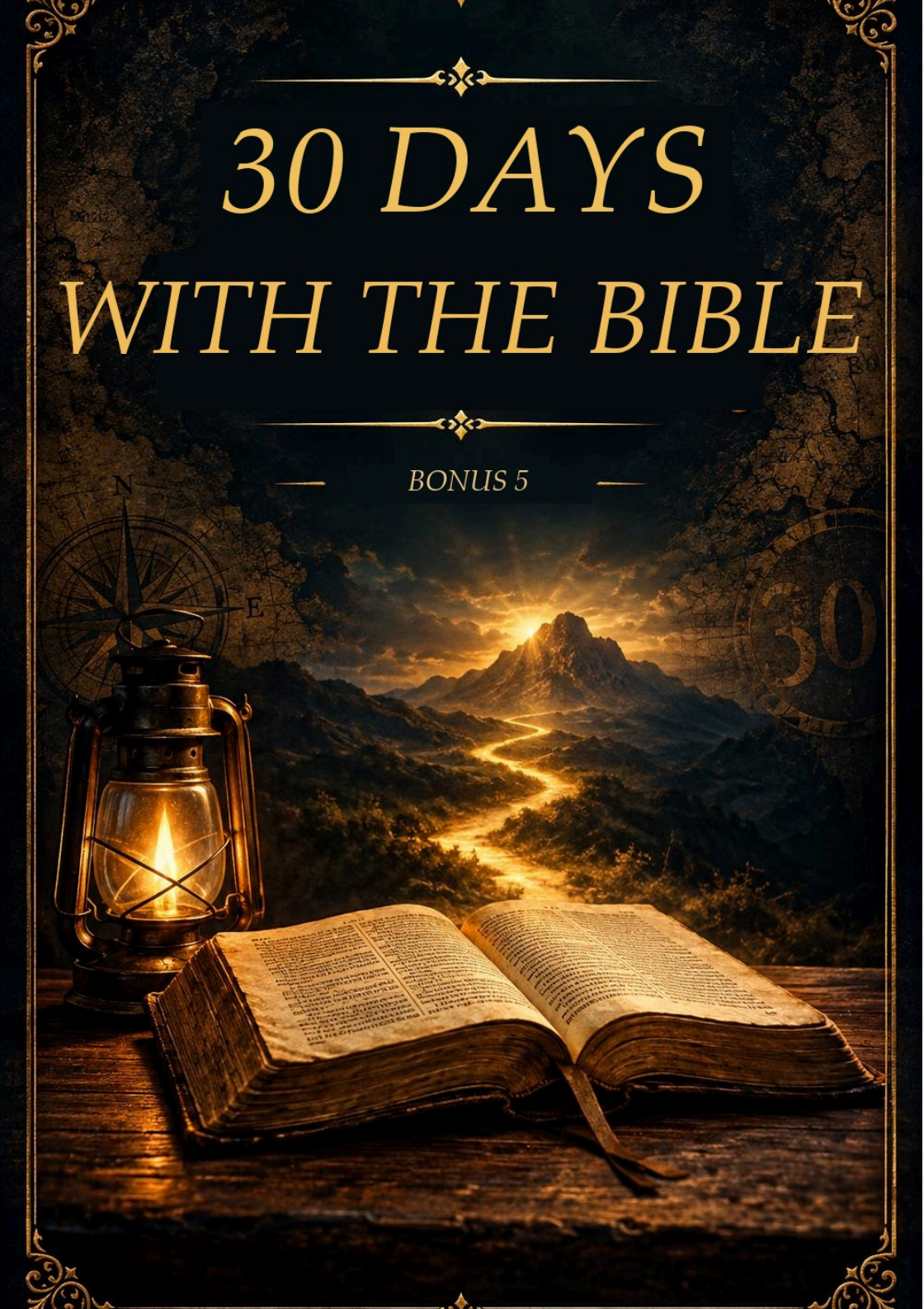
30 DAYS WITH THE BIBLE

BONUS 5



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A monthly guide: one short passage a day, from Genesis to Acts and the Letter to the Romans

This plan takes you through the Bible in thirty days, with each day taking about fifteen minutes. It is not about hurrying, but about a calm, steady rhythm that will become a habit over time. Read the passage in your Bible, find the place on the map, picture the scene, learn the historical background, and return to the text. All you need is an open Bible, a notebook, and the Biblical World 3D atlas close at hand. If one day you run out of time, no harm done: come back the next day and catch up without guilt.

Each day follows a fixed order of five steps and ends with a short question. First, read slowly, ideally aloud. Then check the place in the right part of the atlas and look closely at the route and the lay of the land. Imagination helps you remember the scene, and context guards against misreading. Finally, read the passage again and notice what you missed before. The plan works well in a family, a community, or a parish group, where everyone can answer the question of the day.

1 The Beginning of Everything

READ · Gen 1:1–5 **LOCATE** · This account has no address on the map, because it concerns the beginning of the world. Open Part 1 and see how the atlas sets the creation story beside the lands of the ancient Near East. **IMAGINE** · Picture a dark, formless deep, and in it the first flash of light. Feel the rhythm change: day comes, then night. **UNDERSTAND** · The biblical author describes the world through order and rhythm, not a laboratory protocol. For people living among the great civilizations of Mesopotamia and Egypt, it was a confession that one God stands at the beginning of everything. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how often the motif of word and separation recurs: light from darkness, day from night. Observe who acts here and how calmly it unfolds. **QUESTION** · What in my life needs a little light and order today?

2 A Garden Between Rivers

READ · Gen 2:8–15 **LOCATE** · Open Part 1 and find the map of Mesopotamia with the Tigris and Euphrates. Eden cannot be placed on a map, so the atlas shows only the land referred to by the names of the rivers. **IMAGINE** · Picture greenery surrounded by dry steppe and a stream dividing into four branches. You hear the rush of water and feel the damp air. **UNDERSTAND** · For people of a desert region, a garden with water was a picture of life and security. The river names point to Mesopotamia, but the text is above all a story of humanity's calling to work and to care for the land. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the verbs: to till and to keep. See what role the human is given and how important water is here. **QUESTION** · How can I care today for the piece of the world entrusted to me?

3 The Ark on the Mountains

READ · Gen 8:1–5 **LOCATE** · Open Part 1 and look at the map of Armenia and upper Mesopotamia. Traditionally Mount Ararat lies in eastern Turkey, but the text speaks generally of the mountains of Ararat. **IMAGINE** · Picture a huge boat stranded among the clouds and the receding water slowly uncovering the peaks. Silence falls after a long storm. **UNDERSTAND** · The text speaks of the mountains of Ararat, a region in ancient Urartu, not one specific summit. Israel's neighbors knew similar flood stories, but the Bible shows in it God's faithfulness to those he saved. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how slowly the water recedes and how much patience the waiting demands. Look at the word that opens the passage: God remembered. **QUESTION** · What am I waiting for in my life, and how can I endure this time patiently?

4 The Tower and the City

READ · Gen 11:1–9 **LOCATE** · Open Part 1 and find the plain of Shinar in lower Mesopotamia. The atlas links it with the region of Babylonia, the area around later Babylon. **IMAGINE** · Picture a flat plain where brick walls rise and a stepped tower reaches for the sky. Hundreds of workers bustle all around. **UNDERSTAND** · In Mesopotamia, ziggurats were built of kiln-fired brick, matching the text's detail about brick and tar. The story shows the pride of people who want to make a name for themselves and avoid being scattered. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the question of who truly comes down and looks. Observe the contrast between human effort and the simplicity of God's response. **QUESTION** · Where am I seeking my own greatness instead of serving others?

5 Setting Out Without a Map

READ · Gen 12:1–9 **LOCATE** · Open Part 2 and trace Abram's route from Haran through Shechem and Bethel toward the Negev. The distance from Haran to Canaan is about 800 km (500 mi). **IMAGINE** · Picture a caravan of sheep, tents, and servants setting out toward an unknown land. Each evening camp is pitched and a fire lit. **UNDERSTAND** · Abram had no precise destination, only a promise. The route followed the Fertile Crescent, because that was where water, pastures, and known trade roads lay. **READ AGAIN** · See how often words of promise and blessing appear. Notice also that Abram builds altars along the way, without waiting to reach his goal. **QUESTION** · What step of faith am I invited to take today, even though I do not know the whole road?

6 The Mountain of Testing

READ · Gen 22:1–14 **LOCATE** · Open Part 2 and find the region of Moriah, traditionally identified with the hill of Jerusalem. From Beersheba it is about 80 km (50 mi) of walking to the north. **IMAGINE** · Picture a father and son climbing in silence up a stony slope, carrying wood. Each step is heavier than the last. **UNDERSTAND** · The journey took three days, showing the decision was not hasty. Jewish and Christian tradition connects this place with the Temple Mount, though the text itself gives only the name of the land of Moriah. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the repeated words: here I am. Observe who provides the offering and how the story ends. **QUESTION** · What is hard for me to trust God with, even though I know he is faithful?

7 The Ladder at Bethel

READ · Gen 28:10–19 **LOCATE** · Open Part 2 and find Jacob's route from Beersheba toward Haran. Bethel lies about 15 km (9 mi) north of Jerusalem, on a rocky hill. **IMAGINE** · Picture a lone traveler sleeping under the open sky with a stone under his head. In a dream he sees a stairway joining earth to heaven. **UNDERSTAND** · Jacob was fleeing his brother's anger, so he was without the protection of family. The Bethel region is rocky highland where stones lie everywhere, so a stone pillow is no surprise. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the promise made to a fugitive. See that God comes to a person in a place where no one expected him. **QUESTION** · In what unexpected place in my life might God have been present?

8 Down to Egypt

READ · Gen 37:12–28 **LOCATE** · Open Part 2 and find Joseph's road from Hebron through Shechem to Dothan, and from there by caravan to Egypt. The whole journey is about 400 km (250 mi). **IMAGINE** · Picture a young boy in a colorful robe searching for his brothers among the hills. Soon he sees them, and in the distance the merchants' camels raise dust. **UNDERSTAND** · Dothan lay on a trade route joining Syria and Egypt, so merchant caravans passed there regularly. Egypt bought spices, balms, and slaves, which explains how Joseph could vanish so quickly. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how many people take part in this story: Jacob, Judah, Reuben, the merchants. See that God is not yet named here, yet works in the background. **QUESTION** · How can I respond to harm without revenge?

9 The Bush in the Desert

READ · Exod 3:1–10 **LOCATE** · Open Part 3 and find Horeb, also called the mountain of God, in Sinai or in Midian. The location is traditional, and its exact site remains a subject of research. **IMAGINE** · Picture a shepherd leading sheep through the wilderness and a bush that burns yet is not consumed. Silence reigns all around. **UNDERSTAND** · Moses tended flocks in Midian after fleeing Egypt, so he knew the desert. The mountain steppe of Sinai offers little water, so shepherds often traveled for days to feed their animals. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the command to take off his sandals and what God says about the suffering of his people. See how Moses reacts to the calling. **QUESTION** · What holds me back most when I feel called to act?

10 The Road Through the Water

READ · Exod 14:15–22 **LOCATE** · Open Part 3 and look at the map of the Exodus from Egypt. The exact crossing point is disputed, and the atlas shows the lake region north of the Gulf of Suez. **IMAGINE** · Picture a crowd of people and animals standing between an army and the water. A strong wind blows all night, and the water withdraws. **UNDERSTAND** · The Hebrew term often translated Red Sea literally means Sea of Reeds. It may point to an area of lakes and marshes in the east of the Nile delta, but the text focuses on God's deliverance. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the words: do not be afraid. See who is to act and who is only to go forward. **QUESTION** · What obstacle do I face, and what does it mean for me simply to go forward?

11 The Covenant Under the Mountain

READ · Exod 19:1–6 **LOCATE** · Open Part 3 and find Sinai on the Sinai Peninsula. Traditionally Jebel Musa is indicated, about 2,285 m (7,500 ft) above sea level, though the identification is not certain. **IMAGINE** · Picture a camp pitched at the foot of an enormous mountain, with clouds hovering above it. The people look up and are silent. **UNDERSTAND** · The journey from Egypt to Sinai took three months, which fits the harsh terrain. The scene has the character of a covenant, like the treaties neighboring states made with their subjects, but here the partner is God. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the image of eagles' wings and the description of the people as a special treasure. See that everything begins with a reminder of what God has already done. **QUESTION** · How do I respond to a gift I have not earned?

12 The View from Nebo

READ · Deut 34:1–5 **LOCATE** · Open Part 3 and find Mount Nebo in Transjordan, about 1 km (0.6 mi) from the Jordan in a straight line. From here you can see the Jordan Valley and the area around Jericho. **IMAGINE** · Picture an old leader standing on the summit, gazing at the green of an oasis in the distance. Behind him stretches the desert, before him the Promised Land. **UNDERSTAND** · From Mount Nebo, about 800 m (2,600 ft) high, on a clear day you can see the Dead Sea and the oasis of Jericho. For the people gathered on the plains of Moab, this was the last stage of a forty-year journey. **READ AGAIN** · Notice what Moses sees and what he is not allowed to touch. See in what tone his death is told. **QUESTION** · How do I accept that I will not finish everything I began?

13 Crossing the Jordan

READ · Josh 3:14–17 **LOCATE** · Open Part 4 and find the ford on the Jordan near Jericho. The river lies about 250 m (820 ft) below sea level, in one of the deepest depressions on Earth. **IMAGINE** · Picture priests with the ark stepping into rushing water and a crowd waiting on the bank. Suddenly the current slows, and the people move. **UNDERSTAND** · The Jordan usually floods in spring, at the time of the barley and wheat harvest, so the crossing was exceptionally difficult. The story recalls the exodus from Egypt: just as the water once parted, now it opens the way into the land. **READ AGAIN** · Notice that the priests go first, before anything changes. See how the text links this event with the earlier crossing of the sea. **QUESTION** · What first step should I take today before I see any result?

14 Three Hundred at the Spring

READ · Judg 7:1–8 **LOCATE** · Open Part 4 and find the spring of Harod at the foot of Mount Gilboa, on the edge of the Jezreel plain. It is traditionally identified with the spring of Ain Jalut. **IMAGINE** · Picture an army going down to the water while the commander watches how each man drinks. Only a few soldiers remain in the ranks. **UNDERSTAND** · The Jezreel plain was a natural road for armies and caravans, so battles were often fought there. Reducing the army to three hundred men shows that victory does not depend on numbers. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how the men are chosen and the role of water. See that Gideon is given a number that seems too small. **QUESTION** · What do I do with my own weakness: hide it or entrust it to God?

15 Return to Bethlehem

READ · Ruth 1:1–5; 1:15–19 **LOCATE** · Open Part 4 and trace the road of Naomi and Ruth from Moab to Bethlehem. It is about 90 km (56 mi) across Transjordan, the ford on the Jordan, and the hills of Judah. **IMAGINE** · Picture two women walking on foot, one older, one young. They approach a town where an unfamiliar future awaits them. **UNDERSTAND** · Moab lay on the plateau east of the Dead Sea. Widows without family protection lived in poverty, so Ruth's decision to stay with her mother-in-law was brave and required a journey through dangerous terrain. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the words of loyalty spoken by Ruth and the reaction of the people of Bethlehem. Observe the season of the year in which they enter the town. **QUESTION** · To whom can I show faithfulness today without expecting a reward?

16 The Valley of the Terebinths

READ · 1 Sam 17:40–50 **LOCATE** · Open Part 5 and find the Valley of Elah (the Terebinths) in the Shephelah, about 25 km (15 mi) west of Bethlehem. The armies stood on opposite slopes. **IMAGINE** · Picture a dry streambed between two ridges of hills and a young shepherd stooping to pick up stones. The whole army watches in silence. **UNDERSTAND** · The Shephelah was a strip of foothills between the Philistine coast and the hills of Judah, strategic and contested. The narrow valley with its stream was a natural obstacle, so neither side wanted to attack first. **READ AGAIN** · Notice what David uses and what he refuses. See in whose name he speaks to his opponent. **QUESTION** · What giant in my life must I face today?

17 The City on the Hill

READ · 2 Sam 5:6–10 **LOCATE** · Open Part 5 and find Jerusalem on the hill of Ophel, about 750 m (2,460 ft) above sea level. The City of David was small and lay south of the later Temple Mount. **IMAGINE** · Picture a fortified town on a rocky ridge, with narrow lanes and a stream below. An army enters it by way of a mysterious water shaft. **UNDERSTAND** · Jerusalem lay between the northern and southern tribes, so David could make it the capital of all. It had a secure water supply from the Gihon spring and was easy to defend. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the name given to the city and the words about David's growing power. See what the text names as the source of that strength. **QUESTION** · What makes my place, community, or family a true home?

18 Fire on Carmel

READ · 1 Kgs 18:20–24 **LOCATE** · Open Part 5 and find the Carmel range above the Bay of Haifa, about 550 m (1,800 ft) high. The slope descends toward the Jezreel plain and the sea. **IMAGINE** · Picture a crowd gathered on the mountainside, two groups of priests, and altars of wood. There is a drought, and the sky is cloudless. **UNDERSTAND** · Carmel lies close to the Phoenician coast, where the culture of Baal originated. So the prophet appeared in a place where two visions of religion competed and where people linked rain with fertility worship. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the question Elijah puts to the people. See that he begins with a call to decide, and only then a test. **QUESTION** · Where do I still stand in the middle, hesitating to choose?

19 Flight from Nineveh

READ · Jonah 1:1–10 **LOCATE** · Open Part 6 and find the port of Joppa, from which Jonah sails west, and Nineveh on the Tigris, about 900 km (560 mi) to the east. Tarshish probably lay at the far end of the Mediterranean. **IMAGINE** · Picture a harbor quay full of merchants and a prophet walking the opposite way from where God told him to go. He boards a ship and seeks shade in the hold. **UNDERSTAND** · Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, a mighty and terrifying state. So Jonah was fleeing not the hardship of the road but a mission to Israel's enemy. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the contrast between the behavior of the sailors and that of the prophet. See who asks about his identity here. **QUESTION** · What task or person am I trying to run away from?

20 Song by the Rivers

READ · Ps 137:1–6 **LOCATE** · Open Part 6 and find Babylon on the Euphrates, about 85 km (53 mi) south of today's Baghdad. From Jerusalem it is about 900 km (560 mi) by caravan road. **IMAGINE** · Picture people sitting by a canal, with harps hung on the willow branches. Evening falls, and they are silent. **UNDERSTAND** · After Jerusalem's destruction in 587/586 BC, part of its population was deported to Babylonia. They lived there among the irrigation canals of the plain, and the memory of the Temple became their identity. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how strongly the text ties memory to place. Observe what feelings mingle in this prayer. **QUESTION** · What helps me keep my faith when I am far from what I love?

21 Rebuilding the Walls

READ · Neh 2:11–18 **LOCATE** · Open Part 6 and find Jerusalem with its old gates. The circuit of Nehemiah's walls was about 3 km (2 mi), built on the old foundations. **IMAGINE** · Picture a night, the moon over the ruins, and a rider circling the broken walls. From afar comes the barking of dogs. **UNDERSTAND** · Nehemiah came from Persia around the middle of the fifth century BC. Walls provided safety but also expressed the city's identity, so rebuilding required the cooperation of all the families. **READ AGAIN** · Notice that he first inspects the ruins and only then presents the plan. See how the people respond to the call. **QUESTION** · What in my surroundings is worth rebuilding together?

22 Born in Bethlehem

READ · Luke 2:1–7 **LOCATE** · Open Part 7 and trace the road from Nazareth to Bethlehem, about 130 km (80 mi) through Samaria or along the Jordan. Bethlehem lies about 8 km (5 mi) south of Jerusalem. **IMAGINE** · Picture a narrow road, a weary couple, and a crowded little town. For the Child there is only a simple shelter for animals and a manger. **UNDERSTAND** · The census ordered by Emperor Augustus was part of Roman administration, which affected even distant provinces. Joseph's family came from the line of David, so they had reason to return to Bethlehem. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the contrast between the emperor in Rome and the Child in a manger. See how little the text says about details and how much about meaning. **QUESTION** · Where today can I see God's presence in something very humble?

23 By the Lake

READ · Matt 4:18–22 **LOCATE** · Open Part 7 and find the Sea of Galilee with Capernaum on its northern shore. The lake is about 21 km (13 mi) long and about 13 km (8 mi) wide, and its level lies about 210 m (690 ft) below sea level. **IMAGINE** · Picture a morning shore, wet nets, and fishermen working in silence. Someone stops and looks them in the eye. **UNDERSTAND** · Fishing was one of the main occupations by the lake, and fishing boats often belonged to families. Leaving the nets therefore meant giving up work and security. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the word immediately and what the disciples leave behind. See that the call is to ordinary people at work. **QUESTION** · What is my net, the one that is hard for me to leave?

24 Storm on the Lake

READ · Mark 4:35–41 **LOCATE** · Open Part 7 and look at the crossing from the western to the eastern shore of the lake. The hills surrounding the water make the wind capable of sudden changes of direction. **IMAGINE** · Picture dark water, a wave flooding the boat, and a weary man asleep on a cushion in the stern. The disciples cry out in terror. **UNDERSTAND** · The Sea of Galilee lies in a basin ringed by mountains, so cold air flows down from the heights and stirs up sudden storms. The fishermen knew this phenomenon, so their fear was real. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the question Jesus asks the disciples after the storm. See how their reaction changes. **QUESTION** · What do I fear most, and to whom can I entrust it today?

25 The Well at Sychar

READ · John 4:3–15 **LOCATE** · Open Part 7 and find Sychar in Samaria, at the foot of Mount Gerizim. The road from Judea to Galilee through Samaria was the shortest, about 100 km (62 mi). **IMAGINE** · Picture midday heat, a weary traveler by a well, and a woman with a jar who does not expect a conversation. **UNDERSTAND** · Jews and Samaritans had lived in tension for centuries, so the conversation was unusual. The deep well, traditionally linked with Jacob, was an important point on the route and a meeting place. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how Jesus moves from well water to living water. See how many barriers he breaks. **QUESTION** · What prejudice should I overcome today?

26 The Road to Jericho

READ · Luke 10:30–35 **LOCATE** · Open Part 8 and trace the road from Jerusalem to Jericho. It is about 27 km (17 mi), and the route drops from about 750 m (2,460 ft) above sea level to about 250 m (820 ft) below. **IMAGINE** · Picture a narrow, winding road among rocks, where someone could hide around a bend. A wounded traveler lies by the roadside, and someone slowly approaches. **UNDERSTAND** · The road was known for its dangers, since the desert terrain favored robbers. The Samaritan was a stranger to the listeners, so his conduct showed who a neighbor is. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the verbs describing the Samaritan's conduct: he went to him, bandaged, brought. See that these are concrete actions, not declarations. **QUESTION** · To whom can I become a neighbor today in a very practical way?

27 The Road to Emmaus

READ · Luke 24:13–21 **LOCATE** · Open Part 8 and find the road from Jerusalem to Emmaus. The distance is about 11 km (7 mi), but the exact location of the village remains a matter of debate. **IMAGINE** · Picture two disciples walking in the afternoon sun, talking in downcast voices. A stranger joins them without warning. **UNDERSTAND** · Several places traditionally bear the name Emmaus, so scholars disagree on the right one. What matters is that the disciples were moving away from Jerusalem, from the place of a death they still could not believe. **READ AGAIN** · Notice how the disciples tell of the events and what they do not yet understand. See that someone listens before he begins to explain. **QUESTION** · When was the last time someone walked beside me and I did not notice?

28 The Road to Damascus

READ · Acts 9:1–6 **LOCATE** · Open Part 9 and find the road from Jerusalem to Damascus, about 220 km (137 mi) in a straight line. Damascus lies in an oasis at the foot of the Anti-Lebanon mountains. **IMAGINE** · Picture dust on the road, a band of riders, and a sudden brightness at noon. One of them falls to the ground. **UNDERSTAND** · Damascus was an important trading city with a large Jewish community. Saul was going there with letters from the authorities to pursue followers of Jesus, so the surprise was total. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the question addressed to Saul and how little is said of his answer. See that the transformation begins with a stop. **QUESTION** · What would have to stop for me to truly hear the call?

29 The Call to Macedonia

READ · Acts 16:9–12 **LOCATE** · Open Part 9 and trace the crossing from Troas to Macedonia via Samothrace and Neapolis. The voyage took about two days, and Philippi lies a dozen or so kilometers (about 10 mi) from the coast. **IMAGINE** · Picture a night vision and a swift voyage over a calm sea. In the morning a Roman colony with a paved road awaits in the port. **UNDERSTAND** · For travelers of the time, passing from Asia to Europe was not a great symbol, but in the history of Christianity it became a turning point. Philippi lay on the Via Egnatia, the Roman road linking east and west. **READ AGAIN** · Notice the speed of Paul's and his companions' response. See how the travel plan changes because of a vision. **QUESTION** · To what new call should I respond more quickly today?

30 To Rome

READ · Acts 28:11–16 **LOCATE** · Open Part 9 and trace the last stage of Paul's journey from Malta through Syracuse and Puteoli to Rome. From Puteoli to Rome it is about 220 km (137 mi) by land. **IMAGINE** · Picture a traveler striding along the Via Appia toward the great city, with believers coming out to meet him. A long journey ends. **UNDERSTAND** · Rome was the capital of the empire, with roughly a million inhabitants. The Appian Way, paved with stone, linked it with the south, so travelers entered the city by a steady and well-marked road. **READ AGAIN** · Notice who comes out to meet Paul and how he reacts. See that the text ends in calm, not triumph. **QUESTION** · Who on my road gave me courage, and to whom can I give it?

IN CLOSING

What Next

Congratulations, you have gone through the whole Bible in thirty days, from the first words of Genesis to the Roman road in Acts. This is not the end, but a beginning. Return to the days that moved you most and read them in full, along with the chapters before and after. Open the Biblical World 3D atlas to the next parts and follow the routes with your finger. Every place holds more than fits in a single passage. Keep reading regularly, and the Bible will become your daily guide.